security from Turkish ambitions in the future was to relieve the Sultan of his standing in the Islamic world.[128] As for causing unrest in India, the foreign secretary branded such agitation as ‘fictitious’ or, at worst, ‘short-lived’. It was also pointed out that, when it came to expertise, as ex-viceroys, Curzon and Hardinge had a combined experience of twelve years in India, and both doubted the agitation would amount to anything. Montagu countered that things had changed dramatically since Curzon and Hardinge’s days and that India was actually ‘in a more dangerous state today than it had been for the last thirty years’.[129] The following day, at a Cabinet meeting, Churchill added his weight to Montagu’s argument, bowing ‘to the overwhelming evidence, supplied by the secretary of state for India, of the resentment that would be excited in India and throughout the Mohammedan world by the expulsion of the Turks from Constantinople’. Ultimately the decision of the Cabinet was that the Sultan and his government should be allowed to remain at Constantinople, although without a Turkish force under their control; Curzon dissented from a decision he believed to be a mistake.[130]

To the Caliphate movement that had formed in 1919, this assurance was not enough.[131] For the Caliph to be stripped of his powers and to become a mere figure-head and potential puppet of the West was unacceptable. For, as was explained by an Indian Caliphate Deputation when it visited Lloyd George in March 1920, the temporal and spiritual power of the Caliph could not be separated in the eyes of Islam. The Caliph, the deputation argued, was required to hold extensive temporal power in order to have the strength to act as protector of the Muslim world. According to the deputation, Arabia, Syria, Palestine and Mesopotamia all had to be under Muslim control, as well as the holy places of Mecca, Medina and Jerusalem. What was ultimately demanded by the Caliphate movement, which the deputation represented, was the ‘restoration of status quo ante bellum’.[132] As Lloyd George pointed out, however, it had been Turkey that had declared war on Britain, and not vice versa. To accuse Britain of being anti-Turk, or even anti-Islam, as some were doing, was simply unfair, not least as both Germany and Austria-Hungary had faced harsh peace terms, even though both were Christian countries. Why should Turkey be allowed to escape justice?[133]